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The Medicare Cheat Sheet

For anyone turning 65 or coming off an employer health plan

STEP 1

When to sign up

Turning 65: your 7-month Initial Enrollment Period. It starts 3 months before the month you turn 65 and ends 3 months after it.

3 months before	2 months before	1 month before	**Birthday month**	1 month after	2 months after	3 months after

Sign up in the 3 months **before** your birthday month and Part A and Part B start on the 1st of your birthday month. Wait until later and your start date can slide.

Still working at 65?

- Employer with **20 or more employees**: you can usually keep that plan and delay Part B with no penalty.
- Fewer than 20 employees: Medicare usually pays first. You generally need Part B on time.
- Have an HSA? Stop contributing **6 months** before you apply. Part A can be backdated up to 6 months.

Leaving employer coverage?

- You get an **8-month Special Enrollment Period**. It starts the month after the job or the coverage ends, whichever comes first.
- File form **CMS-40B** (your Part B application) with form **CMS-L564** (your employer confirms your coverage).
- **COBRA and retiree coverage do not count.** They don't extend your window.

STEP 2

How to avoid the penalties

- **Part B late penalty:** 10% added to your Part B premium for each full 12 months you could have had it and didn't. It lasts **for as long as you have Part B**.
- **Part D (drug) late penalty:** charged when you go 63 days or more without Part D or other creditable drug coverage. It is added to your premium **for as long as you have drug coverage**.
- **Missed your window?** The General Enrollment Period runs January 1 to March 31. Coverage starts the month after you sign up, and the penalty may still apply.
- **The Medigap window that never comes back:** you get a 6-month Medigap Open Enrollment Period. It starts the month you are 65 or older and have Part B. During it you can't be turned down or charged more for your health. After it, health questions can apply.

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STEP 3

The big boxing match: Medicare Advantage vs. Medicare Supplement

Neither one is "the best". The right one depends on your doctors, your prescriptions, how you travel and how you like to budget.

	Medicare Advantage (Part C)	Medicare Supplement (Medigap) + Part D
How it works	A private plan replaces Original Medicare for your care. You still pay your Part B premium.	You keep Original Medicare. The supplement pays much of what Medicare leaves behind.
Monthly premium	Often low, and some plans have a $0 plan premium.	You pay a monthly supplement premium, plus a separate drug plan premium.
Doctors & hospitals	Usually a network (HMO or PPO). Check that your doctors are in it.	Any doctor or hospital in the U.S. that accepts Medicare. No network.
Costs when you get care	Copays and coinsurance, capped by a yearly out-of-pocket maximum.	Low or predictable costs, depending on the plan letter you choose.
Prescription drugs	Usually built in.	Needs a separate Part D plan.
Extras	Many plans add dental, vision and hearing benefits.	Generally no dental, vision or hearing.
Travel	Mostly local. Outside the network or service area, it's often emergency care only.	Works anywhere in the U.S. with providers who take Medicare.
Changing later	You can switch plans every year from Oct 15 to Dec 7.	Easiest during your 6-month Medigap window. Later, health questions can apply.
Often a fit if…	You want one card, a lower premium and extras, and you're fine with a network.	You want freedom to choose doctors, you travel, or you want predictable costs.

BEFORE YOU DECIDE

Your 5-minute checklist

- ☐ Write down your doctors, specialists and preferred hospital.
- ☐ List your prescriptions, with dose and how often you take them.
- ☐ Know your 65th birthday month, or the date your employer coverage ends.
- ☐ If you're leaving a job, ask HR to complete form **CMS-L564** now. It's usually the slowest step.
- ☐ Have your Social Security number and Medicare card (if you have one) handy.



Let us help you enroll, at no cost to you.

Whether you're turning 65 or leaving an employer plan, Brian will help you get Part A and Part B filed, compare your options and enroll. It's a free 45-minute review by phone.

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